
26th Sunday in Ordinary Time

27 September 2026

Words and Deeds

For the second Sunday running, we find ourselves in the vineyard. This week a father asks his two sons to go and work. One says no, then thinks better of it and goes. The other says, "Yes, sir," and never turns up.

Jesus asks a simple question. Which of them did the father's will? It was the one who actually went.

What we say matters. What we do matters more. Every choice has consequences, reaching further than we will ever know, into our families, our neighbourhoods, and eternity.

Ezekiel puts it plainly. The direction of a life counts. A good person can drift. A sinner can turn. God looks not so much at where we have been as at where we are heading.

The cancel culture of today's world writes people off at the first mistake: one wrong word and you are finished. Christ offers something far better: forgiveness, a real chance to learn, to know better and to do better. He offers freedom instead of shame, light instead of darkness, a way forward, a turn around, and eternal life.

The son who said no was not finished. He changed his mind, and his change of mind changed everything.

Our choices are never purely private. A kind word lifts a household. A broken promise causes chaos and lets a whole family down. And when we cancel someone, we all lose a brother or sister. Saint Paul urges us to have the mind of Christ, who emptied himself in service. His choice to love to the end has consequences for every one of us.

So this week, look at the 'yes' you once gave. At baptism. At confirmation. Ask: Have we gone into the vineyard? And who might we need to stop writing off?

It's never too late to go. The gate is open, and the Father is still waiting.

(Fr Sean)

Announcements

Last week's collections amounted to: **Melmount:** £2660.00; **Sion Mills:** £1135.00. Thank you.

First Friday Friday of this week is the First Friday. Mass will be at 10.00am in St. Mary's, Melmount. Confessions will take place there on the Thursday before the First Friday after 10.00am Mass and on Friday after 10.00am Mass (*if no funeral*). Mass in St. Theresa's, Sion Mills at 7.00pm on the First Friday.

Legion of Mary will meet in the Green Room, Sion Mills each Monday evening at 7.30pm.

We welcome into God's Family through the Sacrament of Baptism:

Paiden Barry McCrossan

May they Rest in Peace

Deaths

Paddy Gillespie, 20 Knockavoe Crescent

Maurice Hamilton, 3 Dunowen Park, Clady

Beatrice Mary McElwee, Newry formerly Ballycolman Estate

Anniversaries

Tommy French, Mary Gormley, Carmel McGrath

John Doherty, Sophia Campbell, Peter Gallagher

Connor McElhinney, Barney McElhinney, Colm Devine

Pauline McGinley, Francie McGinley, Francie McMonagle

Mary Kelly, Kathleen Kirk, Yvonne McNamee

Barney McDermott, Leonard McDermott, Jean McGinley

John O'Donnell, Angela O'Connor, Mary Kearney

Exposition of the Blessed Sacrament will take place in St. Mary's, Melmount tomorrow, Monday 28 September after 10.00am Mass until 6.30pm. The Blessed Sacrament can be adored in the Adoration Room, St. Theresa's, Sion Mills anytime while the church is open.

Vocations In the words of St. Paul in our second reading, we pray that the men called to serve as priests of our diocese will '... be united in their convictions and in their love...with no competition among them, no conceit; but everybody self-effacing, always considering the other person to be better than themselves, each one thinking of other people's interests first.'

"In your minds you must be the same as Christ Jesus."

Serving as a Priest Are you 18 years or older and thinking or wondering about serving the Church as a priest of the diocese of Derry? There will be an afternoon Talk with time for Prayer, Discussion, Questions & Answers in Derry on Sunday 11 October. For further details please contact Fr. Pat O'Hagan at pgoh2111@gmail.com

Thornhill Ministries will lead an introduction to the practice of praying Scripture in a reflective way that will help participants let the Word of God to nestle in the quiet corner of the heart. *'Open heart – Open to the Word'* series of four Sundays in October 3.30pm – 4.30pm, Emmaus Room, Pennyburn Church, Derry. All are welcome.

SVP (Saint Vincent de Paul) in Melmount and Sion Mills seek new volunteers for their outreach work in our Parishes. If you have a few hours per week to help, please contact Stephen Carlin on the SVP helpline number 0770 3717 307. Please leave a message if no answer. Or contact any member of SVP.

Baptism Dates Melmount

October: Sunday 4; Saturday 10; Saturday 17; Saturday 24.

November: Sunday 8; Saturday 14; Saturday 21; Saturday 28.

Baptisms will be at 3.30pm on a Saturday and 12.45pm on a Sunday.

Annual Safeguarding Mass Bishop Router invites everyone involved in Safeguarding to the Annual Safeguarding Mass on Friday 2 October at 7.30pm in St. Eugene's Cathedral, Derry. The Safeguarding Mass will be offered for peace, reconciliation and healing for all who have suffered the pain of abuse. The Mass will also be offered in thanksgiving for the Parish Safeguarding Representatives in the parishes across the diocese, and diocesan staff and volunteers who continue to work and support ongoing safeguarding practices across our diocese. Everyone is welcome to attend this Mass.

Eucharistic Adoration Derry Diocese is renewing and developing its Diocesan Adoration Lay Committee in order to increase the practice of Eucharistic Adoration in parishes throughout the diocese. You are welcome to attend an Information Meeting on Wednesday 30 September at 8.00pm in The Drummond Hotel, Ballykelly. Registration and light refreshments from 7.30pm.

Could You Help Share the True Spirit of Christmas? Each year, volunteers in parishes across the north of Ireland set up a small stall after Masses to sell **Trócaire Gifts of Change** – meaningful gifts that make a real difference to families living in poverty around the world. We provide

everything you need including training and support. All we ask is a little time and a big heart. Last Christmas 50 parishes took part – and we'd love to grow that number even more this year if you would like to find out more about how you can help, please email Mark at mark.mcmahon@trocaire.org or call 028 90808030.

Host for Hospice October is officially Foyle Hospice Coffee Morning Month. We are calling on supporters to help us raise vital funds by hosting a Coffee Morning. Whether it's at home, work or in your local community, you can support your local hospice by bringing your friends together and putting the kettle on – it's a piece of cake! To request your FREE host pack or for more information, please call Ailbhe McDaid, Community Fundraiser, Foyle Hospice on 028 71359888 or email: ailbhe@foylehospice.com

Safeguarding Notice If you have any concerns with regard to the Safeguarding of children within the church please contact Marie O'Kane, the Diocesan Designated Liaison Person (DLP) on +447596500793 or email dlp@derrydiocese.org. *Northern Ireland emergency services:* PSNI on 101; *Social Services:* Gateway Services, Western HSC Trust, 028 71314090 and ask for the Duty Social Worker. *Regional Emergency Social Work Services* 0800 1979 995.

The Parish Draw for September took place on Thursday 24 September. The winners are as follows:

£500: 1871 Sarah Patton – *Mary Quinn*
£250: 1920 Mary Rouse – *Fr. Sean O'Donnell*
£250: 1338 Marianne Patton – *Carol-ann Stewart*
£250: 1977 Roisin & David Wright – *Ann Donaghey*
£150: 1348 Conor Rice – *Elizabeth O'Hare*
£150: 1098 Pat McGuinness – *Juliana Murray*
£150: 1931 Catrina Myers – *Fr. Sean O'Donnell*
£100: 1027 Genevieve O'Neill – *Genevieve O'Neill*
£100: 1085 Gerard McBreaty – *Paddy McGranaghan*
£100: 1119 Maura Diamond – *Ann Donaghey*



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